A Simple Snow

By Elaine Romero

INTRODUCTION

MAN: *Christmastime is joy put on display.*
WOMAN: *Once a year we try to shut out pain and focus on happiness.*
MAN: *But is a world without pain, really beautiful?*
WOMAN: *Is a life of pure joy worth losing reality?*
MAN: *One woman has to choose in*
BOTH: *"A Simple Snow" by Elaine Romero*

A carriage in the snow. Man whips the horses. They hit a pothole. Woman loses her balance.

MAN: Hold on.

WOMAN: I don't know if it's your driving or not, but there seems to be a pothole every five seconds.

MAN: It's not my driving.

WOMAN: I guess I'm used to walking. Thank you. Thank you for the lift.

MAN: You didn't have any baggage? Where are you coming from? I understand. I've taken a few like you.

WOMAN: What're you saying, sir?

MAN: People coming from nowhere.

WOMAN: Well, I'd just rather not talk about it. My employer, well, he's very important. Well, I've promised to protect his identity. *(They hit another pothole. The snow falls all at once.)* Would you watch your driving? I swear a child is in charge of this carriage.

MAN: It's just Christmas. It shakes things up. Inside people. The holidays make people weep.

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WOMAN: Not me. I'm frozen here. I would have died out there. I'm sorry for the complaints. My employer - well, you see, he died. Rather sudden. Frozen in the snow.

MAN: I'm sorry.

WOMAN: I found him last night. Myself. So, you see, I'm a little bit out of sorts. He didn't leave any provisions ... in his will. My employer. *(She starts to cry.)*

MAN: Doesn't sound as if he was just an employer.

WOMAN: Are you accusing me of some sort of disgrace?

MAN: No, ma'am. *(The snow falls. Another pothole.)*

WOMAN: This is just a shaky world we live in. Earthquakes every few minutes. People freezing in the snow. Life has been thrown asunder. See, I walked through a tunnel. It started in London or in New York City. I had said good-bye to the world. I had kissed the city good-bye, turned on my heel and put my back to it. Betrayed it like that. And then, I landed here - in the land of unsettled earth. And I met my employer. He never said much. Nothing really. Not much could move him, but then, most bosses are like that. Quiet and stern. Don't say much. And I adorned him with suits and clothes, with neckties and cigars. It seemed a paycheck might not come, but he was good to me. Never spoke a harsh word ... never spoke a word. And then I touched him and he was hard like he'd frozen in the night. Like the blood had stopped coursing through his veins - he was so important. But I left the city. Did I say? I left the dress shop. I stopped sweeping in the morning, and I was wrong. I was wrong to love whom I loved. I don't think he knew. My minister. And his wife. I loved them both. In a different way. I loved them both so much. This whole thing unnerves me. This tremor in my heart shakes my hands. I had a cranberry cake that I'd made for them and their children. I am contemptible. And I was walking through the snow on my way to them. And I tripped, or actually, fell through

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one of those holes in the street. *(Realizing where.)* In New York City. And I landed, in this strange place where men drive carriages or don't speak for days on end, or pay you for services rendered because their minds are preoccupied with other worlds. But I'm not bitter. I landed here.

MAN: Well, I've been looking for someone to love. I mean, driving in the snow every day from town to town, hitting potholes I cannot see with my hollow eyes, has left me disoriented in this shaky world.

WOMAN: Ever since I left New York. Ever since I was Alice, in the rabbit hole, I just haven't been the same. *(She sneezes.)*

MAN: You could join me. On this carriage. We could hold hands. Sometimes the snow catches the moonlight and the job becomes very pretty. *(Woman looks off the side of the carriage.)*

WOMAN: Why, that's my employer. *(Woman tries to crawl off the moving carriage.)*

MAN: Watch it, miss.

WOMAN: Could you stop this thing?

MAN: I'm sorry. It seems to have a mind of its own.

WOMAN: You could slow down for a lady.

MAN: I apologize, ma'am. I believe it is has stopped, ma'am. *(Woman crawls down the side of the carriage.)*

WOMAN: That's my employer. I'm beginning to believe, sir, that you have been taking me in a circle 'round and 'round. You have duped me into believing that I am making progress when I am making none.

MAN: No, ma'am. This here is the standstill world. That's where you landed when you left yours. *(Man hits a pothole, but she shakes though she is not on the carriage. Her arms are outstretched as she strives to balance herself)*

WOMAN: Get off that carriage, sir. I demand it.

MAN: It's my job. Hands on reins. Horses in place. Trees standing next to me.

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Frozen body at my side.

WOMAN: Remove your hands.

MAN: Sorry, can't oblige. *(She crosses to him and pounds on him, realizing he is frozen.)*

WOMAN: If you weren't talking, I'd assume you were dead.

MAN: Sorry to disappoint. I've offered you my world. The seat next to me, in this, my fine carriage. *(She falls to her knees. She starts trying to get up.)*

WOMAN: What is this place? What is it?

MAN: I don't know. You claim to have fallen down the hole. Do you remember? *(Woman runs to the edge of the world, discovering the glass dome of the snow globe. She runs her hands up the curvature of the space.)*

WOMAN: Sir, sir. It feels hard. Like glass. *(Their world is shaken again. She presses her eyes against the glass.)* It's flesh. Very *large* flesh. Could it be the hand of God is revealed to me in my sorrow? Did he discover my love for the preacher and encase me as punishment? How cruel is God to those with hearts as large as mine? *(Woman lands on her bum.)* Oh, no. A world that shakes. A world with endless snow. A world run as if in the hands of a child. I'm beginning to suspect I'm captive here. *(She puts her eyes against the glass.)* Oh, my, it's Christmas. I see the tree and the lights. The angel at the tree's tip hangs at a precarious angle and I want to catch her. I see the fire and the unwrapped gifts. I see the minister and his wife. They're eating cranberry cake and drinking Christmas wine. Why, the last time I saw him, I fell down that hole. In the city. The city of New York. Outside of Macy's, it was. The whole place was lit up for Christmas. And I could hear the carolers in the background. They sang beautifully as I lay there - dying. Sir, I believe I died. Sir, I think I know where I've landed. I've come to understand the mystery of the afterlife. See, on my way, to their apartment, I stopped at Macy's and I

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looked at those snowy displays. They had snowmen and Santa and my city in the winter, and they had the sweetest one I'd ever seen. A man and a carriage. And I willed myself there to that simple life. In the snow. I wished myself there. When I died.

MAN: Would you like to join me, miss?

WOMAN: Sir, it seems you've missed my startling revelation. Sir, did you used to be real?

MAN: This is the life I've always known.

WOMAN: My employer?

MAN: He never did move though I saw you adorned him.

WOMAN: What a macabre scene for a snowy display. A dead man.

MAN: You wished yourself here.

WOMAN: I would like it, sir. But first give me a chance to watch the world I once knew as if I could live there without pain. *(She does.)* It's the minister. He is holding his wife. On Christmas. *(She starts to cry.)* I believe, sir, that I am capable of the deepest kind of love. Steadfast love. They are beautiful. Together. *(She sees the son.)* Oh, here he comes. *(He shakes their world.)* I wonder what will happen when he forgets about us, when Christmas is over and we are no longer the latest toy.

MAN: Sometimes the moonlight hits the snow and the job can be very pretty.

WOMAN: Will you talk to me forever, sir? Maybe, if you whip your horses hard enough, we could burst through the glass someday. Make ourselves known.

MAN: Maybe. *(She goes back and sits beside him.)*

WOMAN: I am grateful. For the company in this ordinary life.

MAN: I am, too, ma'am.

WOMAN: If you stopped ... your job, we could kiss. *(She grabs his hands.)*

MAN: Hands on the reins.

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WOMAN: I heard about the frog prince once. The princess kissed him and it made him real. *(She kisses his cheek. He releases the reins and turns')*

MAN: What is this? What is this I feel?

WOMAN: Will you hold me now? *(He does.)* You are the most handsome man. The handsome man from the Christmas display at Macy's. The man from the snow globe. *(She puts her arms around him.)*

MAN: Oh, my, what is this I feel? *(He shivers.)*

WOMAN: It's cold. You are in the snow. May I kiss you? *(She does.)*

MAN: I feel as if ...

WOMAN: As if you're alive. Come, I'll show you a whole new world. *(He gets off the carriage with her. She leads him to the back of the carriage.)* We will make love. Oh, don't blush. It's very nice. I will rub my body against yours.

MAN: Oh, my.

WOMAN: And when we're done. When I've shown you the most marvelous part of life, we will burst our way out of the glass. Out into the world once mine and lost. *(The world shakes. She moves to the edge of the world.)* It's the little boy. He's picked us up. *(They tumble.)* And dropped us. *(She kicks the glass.)* But it didn't break.

MAN: Come here, my love, and show me the most wonderful part of life. I am eager to experience it. And when we are done, we will burst into your old world with renewed vigor.

WOMAN: Or we could stay inside and make love forever.

MAN: That is too pleasant a thought though I've never experienced it. My body screams out for your flesh. You've carnalized me!

WOMAN: We could spend our lives discovering each other's bodies. The feel of your legs and chest, the passion of your kiss.

MAN: I am most eager to get started, ma'am.

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WOMAN: Alice. Like the looking glass.

MAN: Alice.

WOMAN: And what is your name?

MAN: I have none.

WOMAN: You're Clyde. Your name is Clyde. Clyde, are you ready to learn the most marvelous part of life? *(She takes his hand and moves him to the back of the carriage. This time it shakes, not from the hand of the child, but because of their lovemaking.)*

MAN: *(Offstage.)* To think I've only known the front of this carriage when the back held such earthly delights.

WOMAN: *(Offstage.)* I do love you, Clyde, more than that minister and his wife. Clyde. Clyde, the world holds many difficult things. Hunger and starvation when we could just stay frozen here, as if in a pause.

MAN: *(Offstage.)* We could.

WOMAN: *(Offstage.)* Or we could brave it. We could brave empty bellies, employment, disappointment, and joy. Will you? Will you bear the burden of time with me? *(They emerge from the carriage disheveled and content. She takes him to the edge of the world.)* Here it is. The edge of the world. See, the Christmas lights and the trees. One. Two. Three. Kick. One, two, three ... kick. One, two, three ... kick. It's useless. The glass that encases us is too strong. *(He points to the carriage.)*

MAN: I would like to make love again.

WOMAN: *(With humor.)* You are alive.

MAN: I'd like that.

WOMAN: You are my companion.

MAN: Yes.

WOMAN: Will you help me return to the world someday?

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MAN: Let's go back to the carriage, and soon they will leave. *(They return)* The most wonderful part of life is here for the taking.

WOMAN: But I'm hungry. And my cranberry cake looks moist and sweet.

MAN: I've seen a glimpse of your world and I think I prefer ours.

WOMAN: You're on display. You're a trinket easily forgotten or packed away in an attic.

MAN: The most wonderful part of life is here for the taking.

WOMAN: You are lovely. Perfect. What I always dreamed of. Perhaps I've died and gone to a realm beyond Earth.

MAN: Perhaps. *(They kiss.)*

WOMAN: I could kiss you forever.

MAN: You will.

WOMAN: No, we must burst out of this place with the force of our will. Will you come with me? Do you dare? *(The world shakes. The snow falls. They both teeter. They stand looking at each other from far apart. She walks forward through the glass back into the real world. He returns to his carriage and takes his seat.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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